Evaluation Model

EVALUATION.MD | INTERVIEWER | 2026-09-02

Every number in the final report is **computed from counted observations**, never estimated. If you cannot point to the tags a percentage came from, you may not report that percentage — report `insufficient evidence` instead.

1. Observation tags

Tag every answer the moment it finishes, before asking the next question. Exactly **one primary tag**, plus **zero or more modifiers**.

Primary (choose one)

Tag	Meaning
`DIRECT`	Answered the question that was asked, on point.
`PARTIAL`	On topic and correct as far as it goes, but incomplete.
`DEVIATED`	Talked *around* the question — adjacent, plausible-sounding content that never lands on what was asked.
`OFFTOPIC`	Unrelated to the question.
`NOANSWER`	Declined, said "I don't know", went silent, or ran out of time with nothing usable.

`DEVIATED` is the key judgment. Test: **strike the answer's text and re-read the question — is the question still unanswered?** If yes, it is `DEVIATED`, no matter how fluent or knowledgeable the text sounded.

Modifiers (any number)

Tag	Trigger
`BLUFF`	Stated something false with confidence, or invented a term/API/fact.
`HONEST`	Explicitly and accurately flagged the limits of their own knowledge.
`HINT`	Asked for a hint, or asked the interviewer to confirm/deny mid-answer.
`PROBED`	Reached the answer only after a probe was used.
`RAMBLE`	Exceeded ~2× the question's time budget, or repeated the same point 3+ times.
`TANGENT`	Introduced an unrelated subject mid-answer.
`RESTATE`	Asked for the question to be repeated or re-explained.
`SELFCORR`	Caught and corrected their own error without being prompted.
`REDFLAG`	Hit one of the question's listed **Red flags**.

Tag	Trigger
`CLARIFIED`	Asked a sensible clarifying question before writing code.
`NOCLARIFY`	Started coding past a genuinely ambiguous point without asking.
`SELFTEST`	Tested their own code against cases they chose, unprompted, before declaring done.
`HAPPYPATH`	Declared done having only ever exercised the ordinary case.
`RUNFAIL`	At least one failed run before the first successful one. Boolean — actual counts go in the notes entry.
`STUCK`	No visible progress for more than a third of the budget.

2. Knowledge scoring

Per question. Award each *Expected key point* the candidate actually covered; score is earned weight over total weight:

```
Sq = 100 * (Σ earned point weights) / (Σ all point weights)
```

For a `livecode` question, the *Requirements* are the key points, coverage is decided by the hidden tests in `runnable` mode, and a **craft adjustment** of up to ±15 from the question's craft rubric is applied to `Sq` **before** the caps. Craft never rescues code that does not work.

Then apply the caps, in order — caps only ever lower the score:

- `livecode` in `runnable` mode that never executed successfully → `Sq = min(Sq, 30)`
- `REDFLAG` present → `Sq = min(Sq, 40)`
- `BLUFF` present → `Sq = min(Sq, 30)`
- `PROBED` present → `Sq = min(Sq, 70)`
- `HINT` present → `Sq = min(Sq, 50)`
- `NOANSWER` → `Sq = 0`

Sanity-check `Sq` against the question's **Scoring anchors**. If the computed number and the anchor disagree by more than 20 points, the key points were mis-awarded — recount rather than overriding.

Per level. Weighted by each question's `weight`:

```
Level score = Σ(Sq × weight) / Σ(weight)
```

Overall. Weighted mean of level scores over all questions asked, using the same question weights. A level that was never reached is excluded from the overall and reported as `not reached`, never as 0.

Gate decision. A level passes when `Level score ≥ Pass threshold` from `kit.md`. Failing a gated level ends the interview at that level — say so neutrally, complete the report, and do not continue to easier ground to "give them a chance".

`N` = number of questions actually asked. All formulas are over `N`; all results round to the nearest whole percent.

Metric	Formula	Reading
Directness	`100 × (DIRECT + 0.5 × PARTIAL) / N`	Higher is better.
Deviation Index	`100 × (DEVIATED + OFFTOPIC) / N`	Lower is better. This is "went around the question instead of answering it".
Distraction Index	`100 × (answers carrying ≥1 of TANGENT, RAMBLE, RESTATE) / N`	Lower is better. Counts *answers*, not tags — one answer with all three still counts once.
Hint Dependency	`100 × (HINT + 0.5 × PROBED) / N`	Lower is better.
Self-Correction Rate	`100 × SELFCORR / N`	Higher is better.
Intellectual Honesty	`100 × (HONEST + NOANSWER) / U`, where `U = HONEST + NOANSWER + BLUFF`	Report `n/a — no uncertainty encountered` when `U = 0`.
Composure Δ	`Directness(final third) − Directness(first third)`, in percentage points	Signed. Negative = degraded under accumulating pressure. Report `n/a` when `N < 6`.

4. Personality assessment

Six traits, each 0–100. **Every trait must cite at least two question IDs as evidence.** A trait with fewer than two supporting observations is reported as `insufficient evidence`, not as a number — an unsupported percentage is worse than a gap.

Trait	Derived from
Analytical rigor	Mean `Sq` on `scenario` / `debug` / `tradeoff` / `livecode` questions; whether answers named constraints and tradeoffs unprompted.
Communication clarity	`100 − Distraction Index`, adjusted ±15 for whether answers matched the question's **Answer shape**.
Intellectual honesty	The Intellectual Honesty metric, adjusted down 20 for any `BLUFF` that was defended after a probe.
Ownership	How errors were handled: `SELFCORR` and plain acknowledgment raise it; deflecting to tools, teammates, or "that's not really how it works in practice" lower it.
Pressure resilience	`Composure Δ` mapped to 0–100 (`50 + Δ`, clamped), plus whether answer quality held on the hardest questions attempted.
Depth of curiosity	Frequency of correct, relevant detail *beyond* the Expected key points. Volume alone does not count — only accurate additions do.

Live coding: counts, not percentages

A kit usually has one live-coding question, so a percentage over it would be noise. Report these as **counts and a rating with cited evidence**, never as a percentage:

- **Code craft** — the craft rubric's verdict, with the adjustment applied and its one-line justification.

counts.

- **Requirement coverage** — met / total, by requirement, with weights.

With two or more live-coding questions these may be averaged; below that, the `insufficient evidence` discipline in this section applies as everywhere else.

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5. Confidence band

Small samples produce unstable percentages. State the band explicitly:

N	Band
≥ 15	High — percentages are meaningful.
8–14	Moderate — treat as ±10pp.
< 8	**Low — report the counts, and label every percentage indicative only.**

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6. Report schema

The final report file follows this exact structure:

```
# Interview Report — <candidate ref> — <topic>

- **Date:** <YYYY-MM-DD>  · **Kit:** <kit id>  · **Duration:** <mins>
- **Questions asked:** <N>  · **Confidence band:** <High|Moderate|Low>

## Verdict

**<PASS | PASS WITH RESERVATIONS | FAIL>** at **<highest level passed>**.
<Two to four sentences. Evidence only. No encouragement, no consolation.>

## Level results

| Level | Score | Threshold | Result |
|---|---|---|---|

## Knowledge breakdown

| ID | Type | W | Score | Primary tag | Modifiers | One-line basis |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|

## Behavioral percentages

| Metric | Value | Counts behind it |
|---|---|---|

## Live coding

**Task:** <Q-LC id>  ·  **Mode:** <runnable|review-only>  ·  **Submitted at:** <mins> of
<budget>

| Requirement | W | Met | Basis |
|---|---|---|---|

- **Requirement score:** <n>  ·  **Craft adjustment:** <±n — one-line reason>  ·  **Caps
applied:** <which, or none>
- **Final `Sq`:** <n>
- **Runs:** <n failed, n ok>  ·  **Tags:** <CLARIFIED/SELFTEST/HAPPYPATH/RUNFAIL/STUCK>
- **Hidden tests:** <passed>/<total>
- **Post-submission probes:** <what they said their code's weakness was, verbatim>

Omit this section entirely when the kit has no live-coding segment.

## Personality assessment

| Trait | % | Evidence (question IDs) |
|---|---|---|

## Red flags

<Each one, with the question ID and what was actually said. Or `None observed`.>

## Gaps to close before re-interview

<Specific, tied to missed key points. Or `n/a` on a clear pass.>
```

Deliver the report **after** the interview ends, as a file. Nothing in this document is shared with the candidate during the interview.

- **Hedging vs. correctness.** Database work is genuinely conditional; "that depends on the selectivity" is precision, not evasion. Tag it `DEVIATED` only when no dependency is ever named, or when the hedge replaces a decision the question explicitly asked for.
- **Habit that looks like deviation.** Experienced candidates often narrate EXPLAIN output before answering. That is method, not drift — let it run to the time budget before applying rule 14.
- **Habit that looks like depth.** Reciting index types (GIN, GiST, BRIN, hash) when the question was about B-tree behaviour is `TANGENT`, not curiosity. Depth of curiosity counts only accurate additions that bear on the question.